ERA 12

The West & Gilded Age Politics

1865 – 1900

Conquering the West · Native America · the Populist revolt

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Who won—and who lost—as America conquered the West and the Gilded Age reached its climax?

KEY TERMS

Homestead Act · the Dawes Act · Wounded Knee · Turner's Frontier Thesis · the Grange & Populism · Plessy

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 6.2–6.3, 6.11 · AMSCO Ch. 6.2–6.3, 6.11

THE LAST FRONTIER

Conquering the West

Frontiers of Opportunity

I

The Mining Frontier

Strikes like the **Comstock Lode** drew fortune-seekers—then big corporate mining.

II

The Cattle Frontier

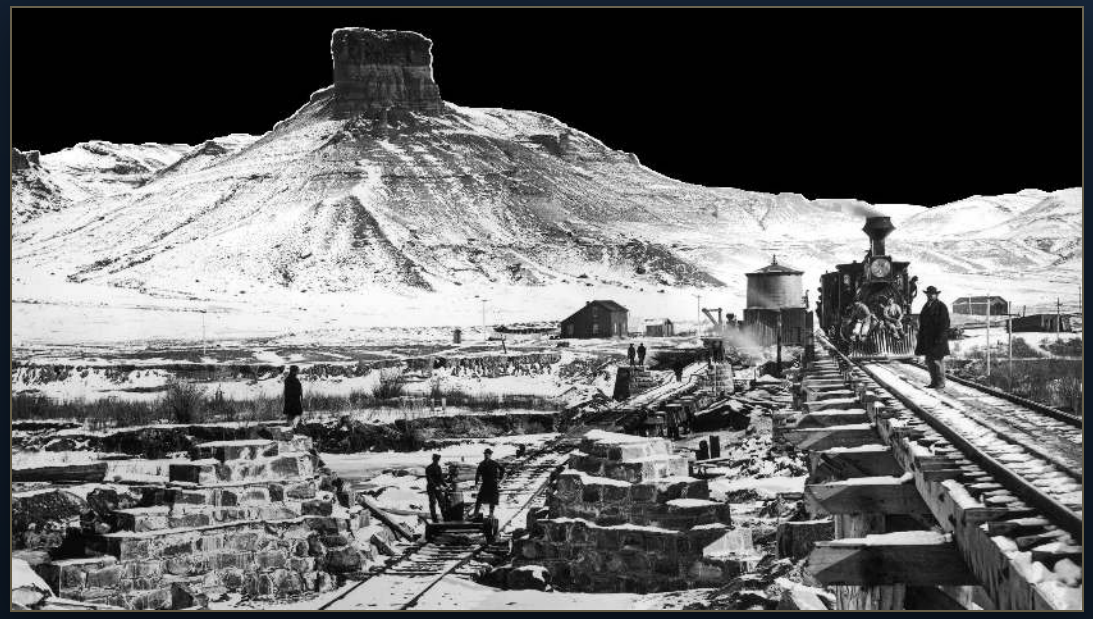
The **open range** and the **long drive** built a booming cattle kingdom.

III

The Farming Frontier

The **Homestead Act** (1862) offered 160 free acres to those who would work it.

Railroads Open the West



- The **transcontinental railroad** (1869) linked the coasts and opened the interior.
- Rail track grew from 35,000 miles (1865) to nearly 200,000 by 1900.
- Railroads carried settlers west and raw materials east—creating a national market.

Farming the Plains

- Homesteaders—'**sodbusters**'—broke the tough prairie sod with new machinery.
- **Barbed wire** (1873) fenced the **open range**; **dry farming** coaxed crops from arid land.
- Life was harsh: drought, isolation, debt, and falling crop prices.



A New Western People

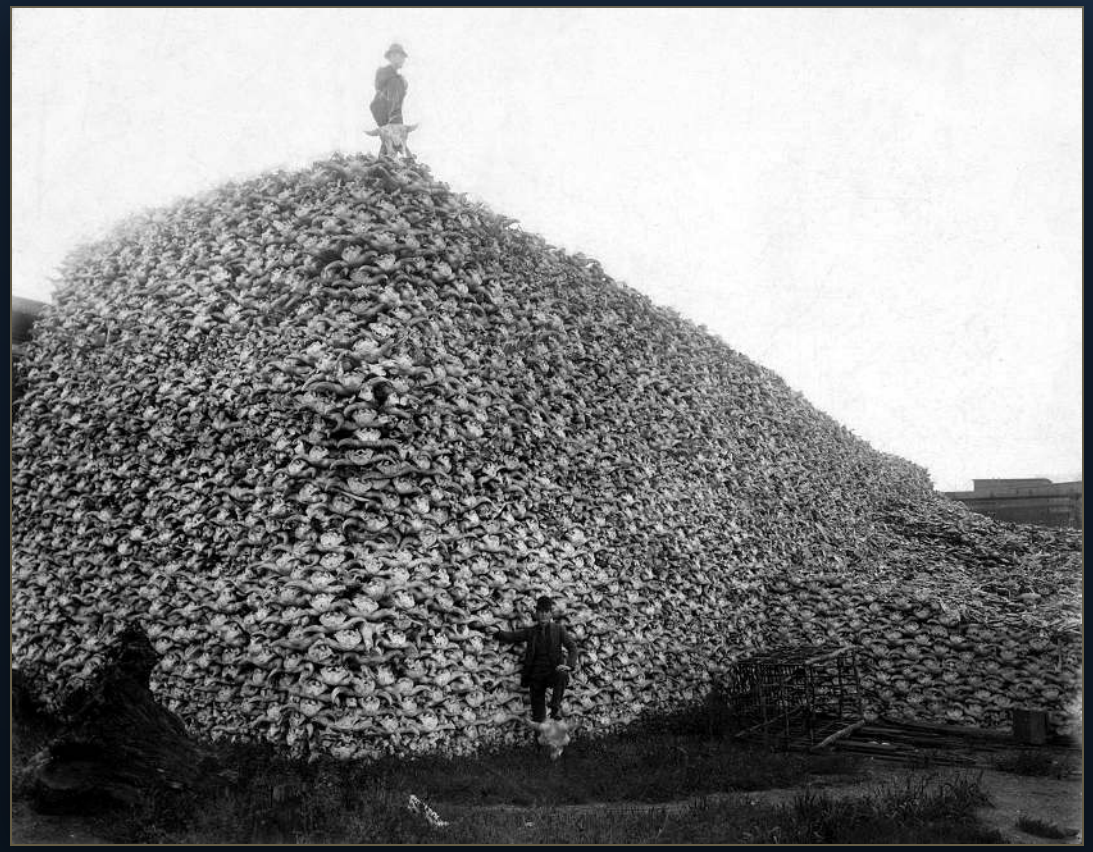


- Thousands of Black southerners—the **Exodusters**—fled Jim Crow for Kansas, led by **Benjamin 'Pap' Singleton**.
- Chinese, Mexican, and European immigrants poured into mining, railroads, and ranching.
- The West became one of the most diverse regions in America.

SECTION

The Native American West

Destroying the Buffalo



- An estimated **30 million bison** once roamed the plains; by 1900 only a few hundred survived.
- Hunters slaughtered them for hides, sport, and to starve Plains peoples into submission.
- The **buffalo**'s destruction shattered the foundation of Plains Indian life.

The Indian Wars

1876

Battle of Little Bighorn

The Sioux and Cheyenne wipe out Custer—'Custer's Last Stand.'

1886

Geronimo Surrenders

The Apache leader's capture ends a generation of resistance.

1889

The Ghost Dance

Wovoka's spiritual movement spreads—and alarms white authorities.

1890

Wounded Knee

U.S. soldiers massacre ~200 Lakota—the wars' brutal end.

Geronimo & the End of Resistance

- **Geronimo**, an Apache leader, fought white settlement for 15 years.
- His 1886 surrender marked the effective end of the Indian Wars.
- The **Wounded Knee** massacre (1890) was the tragic final chapter.



The Dawes Act, 1887



- The **Dawes Severalty Act** broke up **reservations** into 160-acre family plots.
- 'Surplus' land was sold to whites—Native peoples lost ~**86 million of 130 million acres**.
- Boarding schools like **Carlisle** sought to 'Americanize' Indian children by erasing their culture.

The Frontier 'Closes'

1890

The census finds no continuous frontier line

Historian **Frederick Jackson Turner** argued the frontier had shaped American democracy and character—and warned that with it gone, a defining era of American history had ended.

SECTION

The Farmers' Revolt

The Farmers' Plight

GROW MORE

Overproduction

New machinery and land flood the market with crops.

→

EARN LESS

Falling Prices

Wheat that sold for $1.20 falls toward 49 cents a bushel.

→

OWE MORE

Crushing Debt

Farmers borrow at up to 25% interest—and can't repay.

→

THE VILLAIN

The Railroads

High freight rates and 'middlemen' devour their profits.

The Grange & the Alliance

- Farmers organized the **Grange** (1867) for cooperation and political power.
- **Granger laws** regulated railroads—upheld in **Munn v. Illinois** (1877).
- The **Farmers' Alliance** grew to 1.5 million, laying the groundwork for a national party.



The Populist Party

The People's Party demands a government that serves the people, not the powerful

I

Free Silver

Coin silver to inflate the money supply and ease farmers' debts.

II

People Over Money

A graduated **income tax** and government ownership of railroads.

III

Direct Democracy

The **direct election of senators** and the secret ballot.

The Election of 1896

William Jennings Bryan

Democrat / Populist

- Champion of **free silver** and the struggling farmer.
- Electrified the nation with his '**Cross of Gold**' speech.
- Rallied the rural South and West.

William McKinley

Republican

- Defender of the **gold standard** and big business.
- Backed by industry and the urban Northeast.
- **Won**—ending the **Populist** moment.

Plessy v. Ferguson, 1896

I

The Case

Homer Plessy challenged a Louisiana law segregating railroad cars.

II

The Ruling

The Supreme Court upheld segregation as constitutional.

III

'Separate but Equal'

The doctrine legalized **Jim Crow** for the next 58 years.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The West & Gilded Age Politics

1. **Railroads, mining, ranching, and the Homestead Act** drew a diverse wave of settlers and closed the frontier by 1890.

2. U.S. policy crushed Native resistance (**Little Bighorn**, **Geronimo**, **Wounded Knee**) and forced **assimilation** through the **Dawes Act**.

3. Struggling farmers built the **Grange, the Alliance, and the Populist Party**—peaking in **1896**—while **Plessy v. Ferguson** enshrined '**separate but equal**.'

DISCUSS & APPLY

The West & Gilded Age Politics

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **railroads and federal land policy** transformed the trans-Mississippi West.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did U.S. policy toward Native Americans shift from **reservations** to **assimilation**—and to what end?

ARGUMENTATION

Was **Populism** a backward-looking protest or a genuine reform movement? Make and defend a claim.

Up next — **Class 36: The New Imperialism** (America looks overseas)